

James Bowden

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EDUCATION

California Institute of Technology

B.S. Computer Science, Data Science Minor

2019 – Jun 2023

GPA: 4.0

EXPERIENCE

Ryan Adams Group (LIPS), Princeton

Jun 2022 – Present

- Reframing topology optimization of mechanical structures with deep implicit surfaces to be able to specify functional design priors
- Creating end-to-end differentiable pipeline for rational design of 2/3-D materials given arbitrary mechanical objectives, e.g., precise multi-stability in metamaterials

Katie Bouman Group, Caltech

Jan 2022 – Present

- Building from CycleGAN to exaggerate important decision features in image data for model explainability and design of models consistent with domain-expert priors

Anima Anandkumar Group, Caltech

Jan – Mar 2022

- Worked on efficiently training diffusion models by partitioning ~200K-D data in Fourier domain and hierarchically conditioning high-res. signals on lower-frequency (global) signals
- Cut diffusion sampling time from ~14hrs to ~2hrs in early tests by replacing convolutional network (“overfit” to images) with simpler MLP architectures (ReZero-net) for freq. domain

Yisong Yue Group, Caltech

Jun 2020 – Present

- Integrated Deep Kernel Learning (DKL) with BayesOpt (BO) to find global optima faster via improved model fitting on complex, high-dimensional datasets where GPs struggle
- Created “fully-Bayesian” active learning pipeline with posterior sampling methods (Thompson sampling and Monte Carlo dropout)
- Helped develop learned region-of-interest DK-BO to adaptively filter candidate datapoints
- Developing (multi-fidelity) DK-BO for real-world rational design applications including COVID antibody engineering and nanophotonics filter design in collaboration with LLNL, UChicago

Software Engineering Intern, Uber Driver Trip Pricing

Jun – Sept 2021

- Designed conditional models to increase driver offer acceptance, trip completion rates
- Pioneered geo-time embedding to create country-wide model with cold-start prediction capabilities for transfer learning

Head Teaching Assistant, Caltech

Sept 2020 – Present

- Hold office hours, write assignments, give code reviews, lead lab section, grade code, instill good development practices. As Head TA for CS 2, hire/train/support/manage 18 other TAs.
CS 156ab: **Machine Learning** [FA 21/22 SP 22/23] • CS 24: **Computing Systems** [FA 21] • CS 3: **Software Design** [SP 21] • CS 2: **Data Structures/Algorithms** [WI 21/22/23] • CS 1: **Intro CS** [FA 20]

PUBLICATIONS

Learning Region of Interest for Bayesian Optimization with Adaptive Level-Set Estimation

F. Zhang, J. Song, J. Bowden, A. Ladd, Y. Yue, T. Desautels, Y. Chen.

ICML ReALML Workshop 2022. <https://realworldml.github.io/files/cr/paper63.pdf>

Deep Kernel Bayesian Optimization

J. Bowden, J. Song, Y. Chen, Y. Yue, T. Desautels.

Pre-print 2021. <https://www.osti.gov/biblio/1811769-deep-kernel-bayesian-optimization>

Bridge-Group: An Opt-In Recitation Section to Facilitate the Transition from CS1 to CS2

E. Gurcan, J. Bowden, A. Blank.

RESPECT 2022. https://james-bowden.github.io/pages/teaching/bridge_group

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EXPERIENCE, CONT'D

ML Researcher, Caltech (Independent Group Project)

Mar – Jun 2022

- Developed domain-aware data augmentation techniques for graph-structured data to better train GNNs, particularly for molecule data predictive of HIV binding effectivity
- Generated *de novo* graphs to make model invariant to inner nodes (less influence on binding) by randomly replacing central nodes with similar atoms, and invariant to non-binding outer nodes by randomly adding small atoms to degree 3 nodes with some probability
- Selected subgraphs to ignore/collapse interior chemical rings less likely to influence binding

ML Researcher, Caltech (Independent Group Project)

Mar – Jun 2021

- Devised neural architecture search method using PAC-Bayes theory that utilizes untrained networks to evaluate objectives 50x faster, w/ randomly-sampled weights as performance proxy
- Designed perturbation objective employing Monte Carlo dropout to approximate α -robustness and local weight space flatness; this objective was predictive of test accuracy

ML Engineer, Caltech (Group Projects)

Jan – Mar 2021

- Wildfire prediction: preprocessed noisy data, tested/tuned a variety of model types and chose soft voting ensembles to reduce overall variance while still using strong models with low bias.
- Movie rating dataset: Made interpretable 2D representation, clustering via matrix factorization.
- Sonnet generation: Generated look-alike (rhyming) poems with HMMs, RNNs (LSTM).

Kaihang Wang Lab, Caltech

Dec 2019 – Jan 2021

- Led team of 3 senior students to create automated data pipeline for reconstructing ancestral genomes by reducing sequences to gene ordering data and computing consensus orderings
- Wrote Python tools to inform and assist wet bench projects including recoding genomes and predicting minimum set of genes necessary for life in *E. coli*

Software Developer, Caltech (Group Project)

Mar – Jun 2020

- Created escape game in C, from scratch, with A* pathfinding, physics engine, vision, map
- Significantly reduced lag via dynamic programming

Pamela Bjorkman Lab, Caltech

Aug – Dec 2019

- Developed multivalent nanoparticles with a variety of conserved flu/HIV antigenic regions to elicit bnAbs, neutralizing antibodies effective across different virus strains

Jerry Shay Lab, UT Southwestern Medical Center

May – Aug 2019

- Showed that NIP45 is first known protein in ALT cancer repertoire to bind SUMO1, implying involvement in formation of PML bodies for telomere extension

AWARDS

Rypisi SURF Fellow, 2022. Awarded by the director of Caltech's summer research program.

Associates SURF Fellow, 2020. For outstanding research in computer science.

Thermo-Fisher Scholarship, 2019. For promising biomedical researchers (1 of 6 in US).

Teaching Mode, 2018. For best research presentation in cohort of 30 students.

SERVICE

Caltech CMS DEI Committee, 2022 – 2023. Working to improve department treatment of identity.

Caltech Academics & Research Committee, 2021 – 2022. Advocated for student interests.

SURF Ambassador, 2020 & 2021. Advised, supported Caltech summer research fellows.